



Kick Athletics

FOR PARENTS OF YOUTH ATHLETES

The 7-Day Youth Athlete *Performance Plan*

One small change per day across the five factors that show up in every youth sports performance study. No shopping list required. No supplements. Just the ground game most families skip.

For: athletes ages 9 to 15

Time: ~5 minutes per day

Cost: free

Sport: any

BEFORE YOU START

This plan is built around five performance factors: nutrition, hydration, sleep, recovery, and game routine. We are not trying to change your life this week. Pick one thing per day. If it works, keep it. If it does not, drop it.

Your athlete does not need to know this is a plan. Just quietly change one thing at a time.

DAY 1 · NUTRITION & HYDRATION

The Water Bottle Rule

Do this

Get your athlete a 32oz water bottle they actually like. Something they will carry. The rule: refill it before school, refill it after school, and refill it during dinner. Three fills a day.

Why it works

Most youth athletes are chronically underhydrated. Even a 1 to 2 percent drop in body water shows up as slower reactions and more mistakes late in games. The fix is boring and it works.

What to watch for

Bathroom trips increase for a few days. That is the goal. Their body is catching up.

DAY 2 · NUTRITION

The Real Snack Swap

Do this

Before their practice today, swap the packaged snack for real food.

Options

- Banana and a handful of almonds
- Apple with peanut butter
- Turkey sandwich on whole wheat
- Cheese stick, crackers, and grapes

Why it works

Bars and gummies are marketing. Real food gives them sustained energy through the second half of practice.

What to watch for

Whether they finish practice with the same energy they started.

DAY 3 · SLEEP

The Bedtime Anchor

Do this

Pick a bedtime. Any bedtime. Then hold it within 30 minutes for the next 4 nights. For most 10 to 15 year olds, 9:00 to 9:30 pm gets them close to the 9 to 11 hours they actually need. Phone out of the bedroom. Charging station in the kitchen. Non-negotiable this week.

Why it works

Youth athletes accumulate a sleep debt over the season that they cannot out-train. Consistent bedtime is worth more than any recovery product on the market.

What to watch for

Morning mood. Homework speed. Both should improve inside a week.

DAY 4 · NUTRITION

The Game-Day Breakfast

Do this

Even if there is no game today, practice the game-day breakfast so it is automatic when there is. Timing: 2 to 3 hours before the whistle.

Options

- One palm-sized protein: eggs, Greek yogurt, turkey
- One fist of carbs: oatmeal, toast, banana
- One piece of fruit

- Water

Why it works

Cereal-only breakfasts leave youth athletes running low by the second quarter. This gets protein for muscle and carbs for fuel, both digested and ready.

What to watch for

Test it. Same breakfast, same timing, next game morning. See what happens.

DAY 5 · NUTRITION & RECOVERY

The Tournament Kit

Do this

Pack a real between-games kit for tomorrow's game or tournament. Not the concession stand.

Options

- 2 turkey or peanut butter sandwiches
- 2 bananas
- 2 cheese sticks
- 1 bag pretzels or trail mix
- 32oz water bottle (frozen if hot day)
- 1 small electrolyte packet for after game 2

Why it works

Tournament food is designed to make money, not to fuel athletes. A 12 year old on pretzels and Gatorade is going to fade in game 3.

What to watch for

How they feel in the second and third games of the day.

DAY 6 • GAME ROUTINE

Game Day Routine

Do this

Whatever they normally do before a game, tighten it up. Same order. Same timing. Same one mental cue right before they take the field.

Options

- 3 hours before: game-day breakfast (from Day 4)
- 90 minutes before: leave the house
- 45 minutes before: light warm-up starts
- 5 minutes before: one mental cue (a word, a phrase, a stretch)

Why it works

Elite performers build the exact same pregame ritual every time. It quiets the nerves and locks in focus. Youth athletes without a routine show up as a different player every game.

What to watch for

How settled they look walking onto the field.

DAY 7 • RECOVERY

The Recovery Day

Do this

After yesterday's game, the next 24 hours matter more than most families realize.

Options

- Real food within 60 minutes of the final whistle: protein and carbs
- Water, not soda

- No second training session today
- Bedtime same as Day 3
- One low-intensity activity: walk, stretch, or a family activity that's not competitive

Why it works

The 24 hours after a hard game is when the body actually adapts. Skipping recovery is why some kids look stronger by mid-season and others look burned out.

What to watch for

How they feel walking into practice on Monday.

WEEK 1 WRAP

The one you keep

Look back at the seven days. Which change did they actually stick with? That is the one you keep next week.

Add one new factor at a time. In four to six weeks, all five factors are quietly in place, and you have a very different athlete going into games.

The gap you close is not in the practice or the coaching. It is in the boring stuff that happens the other 22 hours of the day.

WHAT IS NEXT

We are building a full 30-Day Athlete Performance Plan that personalizes all five factors to your athlete's age, sport, and specific gap. If you would like early access when it is ready, reply to the email that sent you this and just say count me in.

Kick Athletics is for parents who want to help their athlete close the gap. Not through supplements or shortcuts. Through the fundamentals most families do not realize they can control.

Educational content only. Not medical or nutrition advice. If your athlete has a medical condition, a food allergy, or a specific dietary concern, talk to their pediatrician or a registered dietitian before making changes.

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